

How we Test



It looks good and the technology is glitzy, but does it do the job?

The Digital Media Test & Research Centre (DMTRC) conducts a series of elaborate tests to evaluate the merit of each hardware and software product. To ensure that our readers have all the information they need to make an informed buying decision, engineers at DMTRC evaluate and review the latest hardware, software and technology services in accordance with the most up-to-date evaluation processes and methodologies used around the world.



The Awards

Digit awards outstanding products by selecting a Best Performance and Best Value winner in each comparison test. The winner of the Best Performance Award will be the product that scored the highest in the performance segment of our tests.

This award represents the best performing product in our tests and doesn't factor in any other parameter such as value for money, features, support, etc. The winner of the Best Value Award will be the product that scores the highest in our value for money parameter which is derived taking into account the ratio of a product's performance and features to its price. The product winning this award offers good performance at a great price.



In Bazaar

The second part of the rating system is used to evaluate individual hardware and software products in the Bazaar section. The evaluation covers parameters such as performance, ease of use, value for money and the build quality and features of the product in question and then arrives at an overall rating.

Here each of these parameters is given a weightage of 25 per cent and is rated on a scale of 5, which is represented by arrows (►).

The greater the number of arrows, the better the product. This simple five-point rating system is designed to give you an easy-to-interpret assessment of a product. For example, a product that receives an overall score of five arrows signifies an outstanding buy!

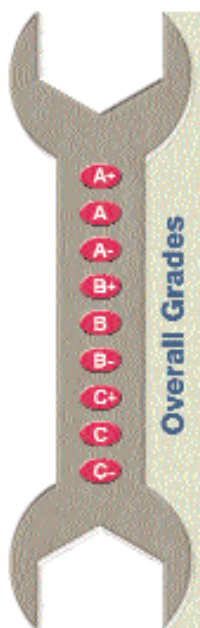
Comparison Tests

We use a dual rating system, the first of which is applied to the Comparison Tests in which we compare the performance of products within a particular category.

Each product is evaluated under different parameters such as performance, value for money, features, warranty and support, etc.

Weightages are then applied to the various test parameters according to their importance for that particular category of products.

These weightages are then used to arrive at an overall grade for each individual product. An overall grade of A+, therefore, indicates that the product is close to perfection.



In Test this Month

On the mat this month are the biggest and fastest hard drives and Linux distributions fighting for the top slot. In the software comparison test, seven Linux distributions were tested, based on their home desktop abilities that would let them act as complete replacements to Windows and let users migrate with ease. To give you the complete picture on these Linux distributions, they were also evaluated on their ability to function as full-fledged office desktops that would let users perform standard office related computing work on them. If you've been looking at switching to Linux, this is where you can start.



The hardware comparison test this month featured 13 SATA, Ultra-ATA and IDE hard disks. The hard disks were evaluated on several parameters using standard benchmarking tools and were also subjected to real world tests, which simulated daily usage patterns on each disk to get realistic performance values. Cost was also factored in to give you the final results. There you have it—find out which is the perfect storage solution for your needs.

Bazaar this month brings to you the inside information on a wide range of hardware—from the Intel Pentium 4 3.2 GHz processor to the Dell Latitude laptop and HCL Beanstalk 4458 PC.

The 5-point Rating System used in Bazaar

►►►►►	Excellent: A brilliant combination of price, performance and features—far beyond expectations
►►►►►	Good: A good buy, better than most products in its category
►►►►►	Average: Reasonably competent but nothing spectacular about the product
►►►►►	Mediocre: Does not live up to expectations, needs improvement in many areas
►►►►►	Poor: has serious drawbacks and needs improvement before it can be used for its target application